Second, Modi is determined to exercise tight control over the Cabinet system. When Rajnath Singh, the official number two in the government, wanted a particular IPS officer as his private secretary, the Modi PMO struck down the appointment. The officer concerned had served in a similar capacity with the Congress's Salman Khurshid. 'Rajnath was fuming but couldn't do anything about it—no one can challenge Modi,' a BJP leader later told me.

Third, there is a certain fear factor that Modi has instilled in his Cabinet colleagues, the fear of the Supreme Leader watching their every move. I had first-hand experience of it when I had to interview a minister for this book. As I was approaching the minister's residence, I got a call from one of his aides. 'Please, can you come from the back entrance?' When I met the minister, he insisted that we not speak in his main hall but in the garden behind the residence. 'You never know which room is bugged nowadays!' the minister warned.

Another story, possibly apocryphal, is that when Prakash Javadekar, information and broadcasting and environment minister in the Modi government, was on his way to the airport, he got a call from the PMO. 'Sir, you are wearing jeans for an official trip—you need to be dressed formally,' he was warned. Javadekar, who reportedly rushed back to change, denied the story when I asked him about it.

Like the ministers, the media, too, finds itself constrained. In Gujarat, Modi had preferred routine information department handouts to any extended interaction with journalists. Now, he has brought the philosophy of keeping the media at arm's-length to Delhi. No high-profile media adviser has been appointed, but Modi's long-serving assistant Jagdish Thakkar is in charge of sending out official press releases in a clerical fashion. As they did throughout the general elections, Modi's Twitter team puts out news updates and photographs with clockwork precision. Ministers have been explicitly told not to speak out of turn or appear on television debates, and instead focus on one-way social media engagement on a strict 'need to know' basis. 'In UPA-II, we could call up any minister at any time and they would respond. Now, everyone wants to be very discreet,' a senior